MEET THE FAMED PRODUCER WHO IS PASSIONATE ABOUT STORYTELLING CHOOSING FILMMAKING AS A TOOL

An attempt to give a unique birthday gift to her favorite teacher at school in the sixth grade with an original poem transformed into an unquenchable desire to narrate untold stories for Bhavana Goparaju, Founder, Jeevi Films. "This penchant for writing poems landed me an opportunity to pen the lyrics for a music video. A friend asked me to do this for him and that's how I decided to take this up. I wasn't really looking to write for films. It just happened," she said, now realising that certain things are just meant to happen.

Bhavana started her career in the industry writing lyrics for a Telugu film 'Priya Premalo Prem'. "When you have to write, you need to have that creative space and time which I couldn't because of the necessity. But I don't want to suppress my passion too and want to be associated with the industry on a more regular basis," she explained. And she found the answer in 'production', which needed both creative and entrepreneurial skills. "I founded a startup earlier when in my undergrad in Telangana's Warangal. I studied electronics, and robotics was an area that fascinated me. I realised the city was an educational hub, but it had a long way to go before becoming an industrial hub. I wanted to take the first step and thus began my journey with the tech startup, since then I have been in the startup world mentoring and also working on different startup ideas with now owning a product development company" she described.

Born to parents who are teachers and activists, this internationally acclaimed producer was exposed to societal issues since childhood. "I have met so many people from different backgrounds. Knowing their stories is what built me. I feel the need to share their lives. Their lives inspire me to chronicle these stories," Bhavana shared. It's not filmmaking, her key interest lies in narrating the unheard stories.

During her younger days, Bhavana established a digital magazine to pay tribute to those unsung heroes she met during her journey through activism. There's one story that pulled her into the quest of many stories on one issue. "I'll never forget the gangrape incident in Haryana. We speak of gender violence but there is caste violence associated with it too. When I was covering Haryana Gang rape incident, I talked to several people from the village and outside and found out it is not just about the rape of a woman. But also about a woman in the underprivileged caste behind the motive of rape, which shed some light to all other previous cases I looked into and led me to many more gender violences including Marital Rape in India and other countries" she commented, adding how shaken she was that she decided to take a break from social media.

"I was extremely pained while working on this. And just when I got back into social media, I got to know about Maadathy - An Unfairy Tale through a mutual acquaintance. It was almost like my calling," the producer remarked. Bhavana did finally tell the story with the help of director Leena Manimekalai. While the duo received many laurels for the film Maadathy, "the best was when people called Bhavana and said: we didn't know such caste issues existed along with gender violence". "One call I will never forget and gave a sense of direction on what I am doing and why is a call from a woman in the audience who called me and just started crying with heartbreak, gratitude and thanked us for making this movie. My intention of telling stories like these is not to make anyone feel bad but to support the voice and space for the victims to speak up and tell their stories and to not be ignorant as a society we already are".

Bhavana's films have won several international awards and several selections around the globe. "I never imagined I'd receive these awards or recognition I am getting right now. Whenever I got a call to speak, I would be anxious. I think I haven't done a lot but just my work. I am highly conscious about recognition getting in the way of doing my work. I keep introspecting myself if I am grounded and being considerate, that causes anxiety. While I want my work to reach a wider audience so that I can continue to narrate more stories, I also want to ensure success doesn't get to my head," stressed the international film producer.

More than Bhavana, her parents are always nervous each time her film releases. "I never told them when I started working on the first film. I revealed it to my parents only when the film was set to release. My parents always encouraged me as long as my education remained intact. All said and done, this is risky business. I sense their tension each time my film gears up for release," she stated.

The next film in the pipeline is a Hindi project that projects the life of a migrant's family in India. "This context seems more appropriate especially after COVID," said Bhavana, eagerly awaiting audience reaction to this upcoming venture.

Hailing from the land of Telugu cinema, Bhavana has strong opinions against commercial movies of southern India. "I have grown up watching Telugu films with actresses like Vijayshanti playing an IPS officer and taking on the baddies. Unfortunately, most films today are patriarchal and women characters are plain beauty statues falling for misogynistic men in the flick, and that is concerning," she rued.



The only mantra in this thirty-year-old's life is to never remain silent. "Silence can do more damage. It's time we all speak up against many issues plaguing our country." Bhavana hopes to inspire and see more women, and more from the underrepresented community like the LGBTQ in this field of "storytelling".